Stereotypes about French people

Hi everyone, welcome. This is the eighth episode of the Cottongue Podcast.

[00:00:12] I hope you're well and feeling fit. As usual, we're going to spend around thirty minutes together, and I'm going to talk about a subject so you can listen to something interesting in French.

[00:00:30] But before talking about today's subject, I want to tell you about an email I received a few days ago. John sent me this email. John is a listener to the Cottongue Podcast. So I'm going to read you his email.

[00:00:30]

"Hello Hugo, I thank you for your podcast. I'm learning French because I want to help my youngest son, who is learning French at school. I only have time to learn French in the morning on my way to work, and in the afternoon when I'm coming home. I can only learn by listening to podcasts because I have trouble reading on public transport. Until now, I've had trouble finding podcasts at a suitable level for me, that I can understand. I find your podcast perfect for me, so thank you for making it!

Thank you and kind regards, John"

[00:01:51] You can see that John has very good motivation for learning French because he wants to help his son. And I think that's very important when you want to succeed in learning a language. It's very important to know what your motivation is, why you're learning this language.

[00:02:17] And you see, John manages to listen to a podcast in the morning when he goes to work, and in the evening when he comes home. That's wonderful because it lets John make the best use of his time and do a little French every day on his way to work. John, well done, and keep it up! Your French is really very good, so I don't think you'll have any problems helping your son with his homework. If you also want to write to me, to send me an email, you can do so at hugo@innerfrench.com.

[00:03:27] So what are we going to talk about today? Well, today I've decided to talk about stereotypes. But what is a stereotype? You've probably heard this word before. It's the same in English. A stereotype is a ready-made opinion, meaning an opinion we haven't really thought about, haven't really reflected on. You haven't really reflected on this idea, this opinion, but you think it's true. And generally, this opinion concerns a human group, a group of people. For example, there are stereotypes about people with blond hair. But there are also stereotypes about professions, for example about police officers or teachers. And of course, you know there are also many stereotypes about nationalities. Today, precisely, I've decided to talk about stereotypes about French people. I think you know a few, and perhaps I'm going to teach you some new ones. Together, we'll try to see whether there's some truth in these stereotypes or whether they're completely false.

[00:05:16] But first, we need to ask where these stereotypes, these clichés, come from, what their origins are. Generally, their origins are sociocultural. That means stereotypes are

shared through education, through the media, or through the influence of certain groups. But what do you think these stereotypes are useful for? In fact, you know that in the modern world there's an enormous quantity of information. So it's very difficult for human beings to understand and analyse all this information. Thanks to stereotypes, we don't need to analyse everything because we have ready-made, preconceived ideas and opinions, and thanks to these opinions, we don't need to think too much. We can think, "French people are like that, Italians are like this." And without even meeting French or Italian people, we have an opinion about them.

[00:06:52] The first category of stereotypes about French people is food. You know food is very important to French people, the things we eat.

[00:07:10] The first stereotype says French people invented chips. You know, in English people even say "French fries". But in reality, it was more likely our neighbours, the Belgians, who invented them. Apparently, the Belgians invented chips as early as the end of the seventeenth century. In France, we began seeing and eating chips a little later, in the following century, meaning the eighteenth century, in 1789, during the Revolution. So we can say it was the French Revolution, but also the "chip revolution".

[00:08:02] Next, the second stereotype concerns a little green animal that can jump very high. This animal is the frog, and you know that in France we sometimes eat frogs. It's a traditional dish. In fact, many foreign countries call French people "frog-eaters". For example, the English call us that, and so do the Germans. Yet you know, we don't eat that many frogs in France. It's a traditional dish, but we don't eat it often. I, for example, have never eaten frogs.

[00:08:58] And you know there's another classic dish in France, and we're the only people who eat it. It's snails. You know, snails are molluscs with a shell. They're small and very slow. And their particular feature is that they're hermaphrodites, meaning they're both male and female. You may know that in France we eat snails with a rather special sauce made with butter and parsley. And it's true that snails are a dish we eat, I think, a little more often than frogs. But despite that, foreigners prefer calling us "frog-eaters" rather than necessarily "snail-eaters".

[00:10:05] The third stereotype concerns alcohol, particularly wine. French people have a reputation for drinking wine at every meal. In reality, we don't drink wine that often. We might drink a glass at lunch and one or two glasses at dinner, but generally that's all. However, it's true that French people drink alcohol very regularly. There's a ranking produced by the World Health Organization, and it says French people are the eighth biggest alcohol drinkers in the world. On average, a French person drinks 11.6 litres of alcohol a year. That's quite a lot! For comparison, in the United Kingdom people generally drink twelve litres of alcohol a year. So British people drink more alcohol than French people. Americans, however, drink less. They drink an average of nine litres of alcohol per person per year. Americans are twenty-fourth in the ranking. So we can conclude that in France, we drink more alcohol than Americans.

[00:11:42] There's something else that's fairly bad for our health and that we do a lot in France. Do you know what it is? Do you have any idea what I'm talking about?

[00:11:57] Of course, I'm talking about cigarettes. In films, when a French person is portrayed, they're almost always smoking a cigarette. French people have a reputation for being heavy smokers. In reality, we don't smoke that much in France. In the World Health Organization ranking, France is sixty-first. On average, a French person smokes 1,022 cigarettes a year. Compared with Americans, well, Americans smoke a little more than French people because they're fifty-seventh in the ranking. So France is sixty-first and the United States fifty-seventh. So you see, this cliché, this stereotype, is rather false: in France, we don't smoke that much.

[00:13:05] Now we're going to move on to the second category, appearance. And we'll also talk a little about style, clothing style.

[00:13:17] French people have a reputation for being very skinny, very slim. But this stereotype is a little outdated because France now also has an obesity problem: there are 6.5 million obese people in France. That represents around 14.5% of the adult population. But it's true that in France, we don't really pay attention to calories. There's something foreigners call "the French paradox". The French paradox is that we eat everything we want, butter croissants, foie gras, things that are fairly fatty, and despite that, French people are rather slim, not very fat.

[00:14:21] There's another stereotype concerning French people's height. Foreigners think French people are short. They often think of Napoleon, and it's true that Emperor Napoleon wasn't very tall. But since Napoleon, French people have grown a lot taller. So the average now is 1.76 metres for men. That means French people are on average a little taller than Germans, for example, because the average height of Germans is 1.75 metres. Americans, however, are taller than French people, with an average of 1.80 metres. Swedes are also taller than us because their average is 1.77 metres.

[00:15:20] There's a third stereotype concerning French people's appearance, particularly their smell, their body odour. People say French people smell bad, that they're dirty. They say, for example, that French people invented perfume so they wouldn't have to take showers. And there's also an expression for when you put on deodorant without taking a shower: it's called a "French shower", a shower "French style". Generally, I try to take a shower every day, and I think other French people do the same, but it's impossible to check. So I don't know whether French people are dirtier than people in other countries.

[00:16:20] Next, there's another stereotype concerning French people's clothes and accessories, particularly the beret. You know, a beret is an accessory worn on the head that is round and flat. Foreigners think all French people wear a beret. That isn't really true any more. Although at one time farmers in certain regions wore berets, we don't see many now. Nowadays, young people in France often wear caps, baseball caps. So if you go to a French city, you'll see caps rather than really seeing berets.

[00:17:12] To finish with appearance, there's one last stereotype, about elegance. People sometimes say French people have a natural elegance. You know Paris is the fashion capital, or at least one of the fashion capitals, and many luxury and haute couture brands are French, for example Dior, Yves Saint Laurent, Chanel and so on. It's true that style is very important in France. We pay close attention to how we dress. It's a way of expressing our identity and personality. But in France, generally, we value a natural look. The rule is not to

overdo it. You should try to stay natural because if you overdo it, it can be a fashion mistake, meaning something in bad taste.

[00:18:26] OK, now we're going to move on to stereotypes concerning French people's character.

[00:18:34] Foreigners often say French people are chauvinistic. To be "chauvinistic" means thinking your country is better than others. For example, you think American cuisine is the best in the world, or Spanish football is the best in the world. When you compare with other countries, you always find yours is the best. So that's being "chauvinistic", that's chauvinism. It's true that there's a form of chauvinism in France. Generally, when French people go on holiday abroad, they like comparing things with France. They compare restaurants, compare how people dress and so on and so on. It's true that in France we're very proud of our country and culture, and unfortunately we can sometimes be a little chauvinistic.

[00:19:46] Next, there's a second stereotype saying French people are xenophobic, in other words that they're afraid of foreigners, that they're a little racist. The evidence is that France's far-right party, the National Front, is increasingly popular. But in the last presidential election, we didn't elect the National Front's candidate, Marine Le Pen. We chose a more democratic candidate who isn't at all xenophobic. Fortunately, as you know, we chose Emmanuel Macron.

[00:20:33] Next, people also say French people are complainers. The French word "râleur" comes from the verb "râler", meaning "to complain". For example, you're waiting for the metro and it's late, so you complain. You say, "Ah, this is annoying! This metro is always late, there are always problems," and so on and so on. So that means complaining. It's true French people are somewhat inclined to complain. For example, they like complaining about their city, their country or their work. And you also know that France's national sport is going on strike. A "strike" is when you don't go to work in order to protest, to demonstrate.

[00:21:32] Another fault often attributed to French people is arrogance. Foreigners think French people feel superior to others. For example, when they go on holiday in France, they get the impression some French people look down on them, that French people have a superiority complex. Personally, I don't know whether that's true. In my opinion, it's a little like every country: some people are arrogant, and fortunately many others aren't.

[00:22:18] What also gives foreigners the impression French people are arrogant is that they're sometimes rude. For example, they don't say "hello", "goodbye", "thank you" or "sorry". In my opinion, this is a stereotype concerning mainly Parisians and people in big cities. You know that when you live in a big city, generally you're always very busy, you have many things to do, and you don't always have time to be nice to tourists. It's the same if you go to New York or London, for example. People there are very busy, so they aren't always very polite.

[00:23:05] There's another stereotype saying French people are lazy. A lazy person is someone who doesn't like being active, doesn't like making an effort, someone who likes doing nothing. You know that in France, the legal working time is thirty-five hours a week. That's lower than in many countries. Because of this, foreigners think French people don't

work much and are lazy. But fortunately, in France we're very productive. France is one of the world's most productive countries. That means workers are very efficient. Admittedly, we don't work much, but when we work we're very efficient, so that makes up for it a little.

[00:24:09] And there's another rather funny stereotype saying French people aren't brave. You know that during the Second World War, French people decided to sign the armistice. That means they gave up fighting, decided not to fight the Nazis. Because of that, people often say French people aren't brave. Fortunately, we have our American friends, who are always there to help us when we have problems.

[00:24:55] Those were the stereotypes concerning French people's faults. But we also have a few qualities. Foreigners often talk about the French art of living. The "art of living" means the French lifestyle. For example, you know French cuisine is highly regarded, that French people like spending time chatting, drinking coffee and sitting on café terraces with their friends. And that's something foreigners envy us for.

[00:25:41] Paris is the fashion capital, but people also sometimes say it's the capital of love. Many romantic films are set in Paris, and people also think French people are romantic. Unfortunately, our Presidents don't set an example. Perhaps you've heard that our former Presidents aren't always very faithful or very romantic with their partners. But in French, when a man cheats on his wife, meaning when a man sees another woman besides his wife, we don't call it an "affaire", as in the English word "affair". Instead, we call it an "aventure", an adventure. So you see, it's a slightly more romantic view of infidelity.

[00:26:42] France is also known as the country of human rights. During the French Revolution, we wrote the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, a text that later influenced the Universal Declaration of Human Rights adopted by the United Nations.

[00:27:09] And finally, people sometimes say French people are very tolerant. You know there's great cultural diversity in France. France has long been a land of immigration. Living together isn't always easy, of course. Racism exists in France. But fortunately, French people are increasingly open-minded and tolerant. In France, especially since the attacks, the terrorist attacks, there's a feeling of fraternity and solidarity. People think we must help each other, help one another. French people try to support one another, whatever their origins or religions.

[00:28:06] There we are, this is the end of the podcast. I hope you've learned interesting things about stereotypes. If you want to tell me about stereotypes in your country, don't hesitate to send me an email. Or if you have questions, you can also contact me.

[00:28:32] Thank you, everyone, for listening to me. Next week, we'll talk about degrowth. Until then, try to do a little French every day and stay motivated. Thank you, and see you soon!